THE LETTER TO THE FATHER

An Original Screenplay

Based on the life and writings of Franz Kafka

Revised Draft -- Public Development Example

October 2026 -- Example Edition

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

FADE IN:

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

I. THE FATHER

BERLIN, 1923

EXT. BERLIN STREET -- STEGLITZ -- LATE AFTERNOON

A narrow street in winter. Bare trees. The light is already failing.

FRANZ KAFKA, 40, walks slowly along the pavement. He is thin in the way that suggests not asceticism but subtraction --- something has been taken from him steadily, over years. His overcoat hangs. His dark eyes are enormous in his angular face. Under one arm: a loaf wrapped in paper and a small packet of tea.

He passes a BUTCHER'S SHOP. In the window: hanging carcasses, pale and meticulously drained. A handwritten price card. Sawdust on the tile floor inside.

Kafka stops. Not because of the meat. Because something is wrong in his chest.

He coughs. Once. Twice. On the second cough he turns slightly from the window and covers his mouth with his hand.

When he takes his hand away, there is blood on his palm.

He stares at it. Behind him, through the glass, the butcher wraps a cut of beef in brown paper. The paper darkens where the blood seeps through.

Kafka looks at his hand. Looks at the window. The butcher's hands, working. His own hand, wet and red.

A WOMAN passes behind him on the pavement, shopping bag over her arm, and does not notice.

Kafka wipes his hand on his handkerchief. Folds it carefully. Puts it in his pocket.

He adjusts the paper parcel under his arm and keeps walking.

CUT TO:

PRAGUE, 1912

INT. KAFKA FAMILY APARTMENT -- ALTSTÄDTER RING -- MORNING

A large, well-furnished apartment in the Old Town. Heavy furniture. Lace on the tables. Coffee already poured. Breakfast already arranged.

KAFKA, 29, sits at the table with bread in his hand and no intention of eating it.

JULIE KAFKA moves between stove and table, setting things right before they can go wrong. OTTLA eats across from Franz and nudges the jam toward him. He does not take it.

A door opens. The apartment shifts.

HERMANN KAFKA enters in a good suit, fastening a cuff. Large without softness.

HERMANN
Is there more coffee, or did we drink the last of it yesterday and forget to order more?

Julie is already pouring. She sets the cup before him without a word. Hermann sits. The chair gives a small complaint under him. He unfolds his napkin.

HERMANN
(to Franz, without looking up)
You look terrible.

KAFKA
I didn't sleep well.

HERMANN
You never sleep well. You should eat more. You should exercise.

Hermann butters bread in four hard, practical strokes.

HERMANN
What time did you get to bed?

KAFKA
Late.

HERMANN
Writing?

A pause. Kafka nods, barely.

HERMANN
Your mother worries.

Julie, at the stove, keeps her back turned. Ottla stops eating.

HERMANN
A man your age. A position at the Institute. You should be sleeping like a stone. Instead you sit up all night scribbling and then you come to breakfast looking like something the cat brought in.

Ottla looks at Franz. He does not look back.

KAFKA
(quietly)
I'll try to sleep earlier.

HERMANN
Good. Now eat something.

Kafka takes a bite. Hermann watches until he swallows, then turns back to his coffee.

CUT TO:

INT. HERMANN KAFKA'S FANCY GOODS SHOP -- DAY

A well-stocked retail shop on a good Prague street. Glass display cases. Buttons, ribbons, lace, parasols, walking sticks, gloves. Two SHOP GIRLS work behind the counter.

Hermann serves two customers at once, measuring ribbon for one while naming glove sizes for another without looking at the shelves.

Kafka enters. He is in his dark office suit, coming from the Insurance Institute. He carries a small package --- something Julie asked him to bring.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

HERMANN
(to a departing customer)
Thank you, Mrs. Novotná. Always a pleasure.

He turns to Franz. His eyes go first to the collar, then the posture.

HERMANN
Ah. Franz. Come, come. Put that in the back.

Kafka moves to the back room. One of the SHOP GIRLS, ANNA, looks up at him and then quickly back to her work.

Kafka returns from the back room. Hermann is already straightening a display of walking sticks by half-centimeters.

HERMANN
Stand up straight.

Kafka straightens, slightly.

HERMANN
Your mother wants to know about Saturday. Dinner. The Löwys are coming.

KAFKA
I may have to work.

HERMANN
On a Saturday.

KAFKA
There's a case. The Kraus sawmill. A man lost three fingers in a---

HERMANN
(waving this away)
Fingers. Three fingers. Franz, the Löwys are family. You will come to dinner. You will wear a clean shirt. You will make conversation like a human being.

A CUSTOMER enters. Hermann turns at once, warm now, expansive, already smiling.

HERMANN
Mr. Procházka! What a pleasure. Looking for something for your wife? We just received the most beautiful Italian leather gloves---

He moves away. Kafka stands alone among the glass cases and perfect rows of ribbon.

Anna glances at him again. He catches her eye.

KAFKA
(quietly, to Anna)
Do you ever feel the buttons are watching you?

Anna stares at him. The corner of her mouth gives way before she remembers where she is.

From across the shop, Hermann laughs. He turns the gloves in the light, finds the seam with one finger, and Mr. Procházka laughs too.

Kafka watches.

CUT TO:

INT. KAFKA FAMILY APARTMENT -- LIVING ROOM -- EVENING

The apartment is set for a small celebration. Good plates. Bakery pastries. A bottle of wine already open.

Kafka sits with his Doctor of Law certificate in his lap. His sisters --- ELLI, VALLI, and OTTLA --- lean in to see it. Julie beams. Hermann stands with a full glass.

HERMANN
Doctor of Law. My son.

He taps the certificate once with two fingers, proud.

HERMANN
Now. We'll find you a practice. Or you'll stay at the Institute and advance. In five years, you'll be running a department.

KAFKA
Perhaps.

HERMANN
Not perhaps. Certainly. You have the degree. You have the mind. All you need is the---

He searches for the word. Makes a fist, gently.

HERMANN
The appetite.

He takes a pastry from the plate and bites into it. Powdered sugar catches in his mustache. Kafka watches him eat.

Julie raises her glass.

JULIE
To Franz.

They drink. Kafka raises his glass a beat later than the others.

Ottla touches his arm under the table. He looks at her. She squeezes once. He squeezes back.

CUT TO:

INT. KAFKA'S BEDROOM -- NIGHT

Small. Austere. A narrow bed. A desk by the window. The family apartment is silent.

Kafka sits at the desk. It is after midnight. A single lamp burns. He is in his shirtsleeves, his jacket hung on the chair behind him.

He writes. Longhand, in ink, in the small careful script that is distinctly his.

We don't see what he writes. We see his face. The jaw unclenches. He leans closer to the page. For once he does not look toward the door.

From somewhere below, a sound: Hermann coughing in his sleep. The low rumble of a large man's restless body.

Kafka stops. Listens. His eyes go to the door. When nothing follows, he lowers the pen back to the page.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

He writes again.

KAFKA (V.O.)
Dearest Father --- I have always been afraid of you, and yet I have never been able to explain why.

He stops. Crosses something out. Writes again.

The lamp flickers. Outside the window, Prague sleeps. The spires of the Old Town are barely visible in the dark.

Kafka writes. The pen moves. The only sound in the world.

CUT TO:

INT. KAFKA FAMILY APARTMENT -- KITCHEN -- MORNING

Early. Before Hermann wakes. Julie and Kafka at the kitchen table. Coffee. The intimacy of the early hour. Julie is slicing yesterday's bread thinner than bread should have to be sliced.

JULIE
He doesn't mean it the way it sounds.

KAFKA
I know.

JULIE
He's proud of you. He just prefers pride when it can shout.

KAFKA
I know, Mother.

A pause. Julie pushes the thinner slice toward him, keeps the heel for herself.

JULIE
You're thin, Franz.

KAFKA
I've always been thin.

JULIE
Thinner.

She reaches across the table, closes the top button of his collar where it has worked loose, smooths it once with her thumb, and leaves her hand there until Hermann turns over in the next room. Only then does she take it back.

JULIE
If you could just give him one sentence he can carry around the shop without feeling laughed at, it would save trouble.

KAFKA
Halfway to what?

Julie looks toward the bedroom door, then at the bread knife in her hand.

JULIE
Halfway to breakfast.
Halfway through supper.
Halfway through one day without a campaign.

From the bedroom, the sound of Hermann waking: a great exhalation, the creak of the bed.

The day begins.

CUT TO:

EXT. PRAGUE -- VLTAVA RIVER EMBANKMENT -- AFTERNOON

Kafka and Ottla walk along the river. Autumn light on the water. The city behind them, golden and indifferent.

OTTLA
I told Father I want to work on the farm.

KAFKA
What did he say?

OTTLA
What do you think he said?

They share a look. A small, grim amusement.

KAFKA
He said you were being impractical.

OTTLA
He said I was being ridiculous. That farming is for peasants and that he didn't build a business so his daughter could shovel manure.

KAFKA
He has a way with imagery.

Ottla laughs. A real laugh, unguarded. Kafka drops his eyes, then the smile gets him anyway. His shoulders loosen before he can stop them.

OTTLA
You should leave Prague, Franz.

KAFKA
And go where?

OTTLA
Anywhere. Berlin. Vienna. Somewhere he isn't standing in the next room.

Kafka looks at the river. The current moving steadily under the stone bridges.

KAFKA
I've considered it.

OTTLA
But?

KAFKA
But I'd take him with me. He's not in the next room, Ottla. He's in this one.

He taps his chest. Lightly, almost playfully. But his eyes are serious.

OTTLA
Then tell him. Not the one in here. The one at supper.

Kafka says nothing. He looks at the river instead.

They walk. The river moves beneath them, dark and purposeful, going somewhere they are not.

CUT TO:

INT. KAFKA FAMILY APARTMENT -- DINING ROOM -- EVENING

The dining room table is fully set. White cloth. Candles. Julie's best china. The LÖWY FAMILY --- an uncle, aunt, and cousin --- are seated. Hermann presides at the head.

The atmosphere is warm, prosperous, suffocating.

Hermann holds court. He tells a story about a business trip --- animated, commanding. The Löwys laugh in the right places.

Kafka sits at the corner of the table, eating carefully. He has arranged his food into small, precise portions. He takes tiny bites. His posture suggests a man trying to take up as little space as possible.

UNCLE LÖWY
So, Franz. Your father tells us you're doing very well at the Institute.

KAFKA
The Institute is--- efficient.

UNCLE LÖWY
And the writing? Still at it?

A brief, heavy silence. Hermann's face does something complicated --- not a frown, but a recalibration.

HERMANN
Franz writes in his spare time. As a hobby.

KAFKA
(very quietly)
Yes. A hobby.

Under the table, his hand tightens on his napkin.

UNCLE LÖWY
What sort of stories?

KAFKA
One man is arrested and never told why. Another wakes up an insect. The usual.

A silence. Uncle Löwy laughs, uncertainly. Hermann reaches for the bread basket.

AUNT LÖWY
It's nice to have interests. My Heinrich paints watercolors. Very restful.

Kafka nods. Gives Aunt Löwy a brief smile, then drops his eyes to the table and reaches for his glass.

Hermann is already reaching with the bottle before anyone asks. Aunt Löwy lifts her glass to meet it. Uncle Löwy follows him into the toast. Julie slides the bread basket toward Hermann without looking up. Kafka watches how easily the whole table takes its shape from him.

HERMANN
To family.

They raise their glasses. Kafka raises his. Drinks.

Later. The Löwys are gone. Julie clears the table. Hermann sits back, content.

HERMANN
That went well. You see? No disaster.

Kafka stands in the doorway. Hermann sits broad and satisfied among the empty glasses. Kafka looks at him a long moment, thumb worrying the edge of the doorframe, then lets go.

KAFKA
No. No disaster.

He goes to his room. Closes the door. Sits at his desk.

He does not write. He sits. The silence of the apartment settles around him like sediment.

Through the wall, he can hear his father humming as he prepares for bed. A tuneless, contented sound.

Kafka sits in the dark and listens to his father hum.

CUT TO:

INT. KAFKA FAMILY APARTMENT -- HALLWAY -- LATE NIGHT

The apartment is dark. Everyone is asleep.

Kafka moves through the hallway toward the bathroom. The hallway is narrow --- it has always been narrow. Tonight it keeps going. The walls press closer. His bare feet on the wooden floor answer him back.

He passes his parents' bedroom door. Behind it, Hermann's deep, regular breathing. A bedspring answers on the exhale.

The hallway stretches. Kafka walks. The bathroom door does not come nearer.

Then he is there. The hallway is normal. The door is where it always was.

He opens the door. Looks at his face in the mirror above the sink. Thin face. Dark eyes. Too awake.

He turns on the tap. Washes his hands. The water is cold.

In the mirror, the hallway behind him keeps going.

He turns off the tap. Goes back to bed.

FADE TO BLACK.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

II. THE OFFICE

WORKERS' ACCIDENT INSURANCE INSTITUTE
PRAGUE, 1912

EXT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE BUILDING -- MORNING

A large, imposing building. Stone, columns, bronze doors already smudged by the morning rush of WORKERS and CLERKS.

Kafka arrives in a dark suit, briefcase in hand. He falls into the morning stream without breaking its pace.

INT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE -- LOBBY -- CONTINUOUS

Marble floor. High ceilings. The sounds of an institution: footsteps, paper, the distant ringing of telephones. A large clock on the wall marks the hour.

Kafka moves through the lobby with practiced efficiency. He nods to a COLLEAGUE, checks his pigeonhole, removes a stack of files, and keeps moving.

CUT TO:

INT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE -- ELEVATOR LOBBY -- MORNING

A small lobby before a single elevator. Metal gate. An ELEVATOR OPERATOR, elderly, in a faded uniform, runs the mechanism.

Kafka waits. Three other MEN wait with him. They talk among themselves --- weather, football, the new regulation on form 17-B. Kafka stands slightly apart, holding his files.

The elevator arrives. The operator opens the gate. The three men step in.

The elevator is small. There is room for one more person. Kafka steps forward.

The operator clocks Kafka, the files in his arms, then the men already inside. He slides the gate toward shut.

The operator begins to close the gate.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

KAFKA
I can---

The gate closes. A clang of metal. The elevator begins to rise.

Kafka stands alone in the lobby, the files held against his chest. The numbers above the gate tick upward: 1... 2... 3...

No one in the corridor looks at him.

The clock ticks. Somewhere deep in the building, a stamp comes down hard on paper.

Kafka shifts the files to his other arm. The top page bends under his thumb.

He steps back from the gate and waits.

The elevator descends. The numbers tick down: 3... 2... 1. The gate opens. The operator looks at him.

ELEVATOR OPERATOR
Going up?

Kafka steps in. The gate closes. The elevator rises. His reflection in the polished metal shows a thin man in a dark suit holding files at his chest.

CUT TO:

INT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE -- KAFKA'S OFFICE -- DAY

A small, tidy office. Desk, files, a window overlooking a courtyard.

Kafka works. He reads a file. It concerns a FACTORY WORKER who lost two fingers in a stamping press. The file includes a medical report, a factory inspection form, a claim for compensation.

He reads carefully. Makes notes in the margin. His handwriting is small and precise.

A knock. DIRECTOR MARSCHNER, 55, enters in a solid suit, carrying the Kraus file and his hat, which he sets carefully on the cabinet before he speaks.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

MARSCHNER
Kafka. The Kraus file.

KAFKA
The sawmill.

MARSCHNER
They're contesting it. Saying the worker was negligent. That he positioned his hand---

KAFKA
The guard was removed. I inspected the machine personally last month. The cylinder guard had been taken off because it slowed the feed rate by four seconds per board.

Marschner looks at him.

KAFKA
Four seconds per board. Two hundred boards per shift.
Three shifts. Forty minutes a day.
Someone chose that over his hand.

MARSCHNER
You inspected it personally?

KAFKA
I inspect them all personally when I can. The forms are unreliable. The owners fill them in from memory. Or imagination.

Marschner sits down, one hand briefly on his knee as he settles. Studies Kafka.

MARSCHNER
Sometimes I think you're the only person in this building who actually reads the files.

KAFKA
(a thin smile)
Someone has to.

MARSCHNER
The recommendation?

KAFKA
Full compensation. Inspect Kraus sawmills within thirty days. I'll draft the order.

MARSCHNER
Good. Good man.

He leaves. Kafka returns to the file. Opens it again. Looks at the medical photograph clipped to the inside: a man's hand, or what remains of it. Two stumps where fingers were.

Kafka studies the photograph until the paper clip marks his thumb. Then he closes the file, sets it in the outbox, and opens the next one.

The clock on the wall ticks.

CUT TO:

INT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE -- WAITING ROOM -- DAY

A long room with wooden benches. WORKERS wait with caps in their hands. Bandaged wrists. Arms in slings. One man remains standing because sitting hurts his back.

Claim forms rest on their laps. A woman traces each printed line with her finger while her husband mouths the words beside her.

Kafka walks through the waiting room on his way to another office. He slows. Stops. Watches.

A YOUNG WORKER, barely 20, sits with his bandaged right hand resting on his knee. He tries to turn a page with his left hand and cannot manage it cleanly.

Kafka crosses to him and crouches beside the bench.

KAFKA
May I?

The worker hands him the form. Kafka sees the printed word `NEGLIGENCE' and the blank line beneath it.

YOUNG WORKER
The clerk said that line matters most.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

KAFKA
It does. Tell me exactly.

YOUNG WORKER
The guard shook. The belt jumped. I reached in before it took the sleeve.

KAFKA
Who buttons your collar now?

YOUNG WORKER
My sister. Why?

Kafka turns the paper toward him and places the pencil in his left hand. He steadies the page with two fingers.

KAFKA
Write: `The guard shook loose. The belt jumped.'

The worker writes slowly, awkwardly.

YOUNG WORKER
Will it matter?

KAFKA
More than `negligence' will.

KAFKA
Then add: `Since the accident my sister buttons my collar.'

YOUNG WORKER
That's not the machine. It's morn-ings.

KAFKA
Exactly.

Kafka rises. The worker bends over the page and keeps writing as Kafka moves on.

CUT TO:

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

INT. CAFÉ ARCO -- EVENING

A Prague literary café. Loud, smoky, full of argument. WRITERS, INTELLECTUALS, and STUDENTS debate at crowded tables.

MAX BROD, 28, is already half out of his chair before Kafka reaches the table. Kafka's marked-up manuscript lies beside the coffee cups and a plate with two rolls Brod has clearly ordered for both of them.

Kafka approaches with a cup of coffee.

BROD
(standing, already half out of his chair)
Franz! Sit, sit. I missed my tram stop. I missed it completely. Because of you.

Kafka sits. The café noise swirls around them.

Brod pushes the plate a little closer to him. Kafka notices and declines without touching it.

KAFKA
Then the railway has my apologies.

BROD
Don't do that. Don't be modest. It's alive, this thing.

KAFKA
I'm not a genius. I just don't sleep.

BROD
``The Judgment.'' Franz. The opening --- I read it twice. I read it three times. The opening alone---

KAFKA
(uncomfortable)
It came out in one night. That's all I know about it.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

BROD
Good. Good. If you knew, you'd have improved it to death by morning.

Kafka reaches for his coffee instead of the pages. He stirs it once, twice, not looking at Brod.

KAFKA
My father would say I should spend the night sleeping instead of writing.

BROD
Your father sells buttons.

KAFKA
(sharply)
Fancy goods.

A beat. Then they both smile despite themselves.

Brod taps the manuscript, then produces an addressed envelope from his coat. Kafka sees it and goes still.

BROD
I want to send it out.

KAFKA
No.

BROD
You brought it to me.

KAFKA
Because you read quickly. Not because you should mail it to strangers.

BROD
Give it a week and you'll sand the skin off it.

Kafka's fingers go to the envelope, then stop on the table.

KAFKA
Send it to whoever you like. I reserve the right to be horrified.

BROD
(beaming)
Done. Start with the roll. Then more coffee.

He wraps the untouched roll in a paper napkin and slides it beneath the corner of Franz's manuscript.

CUT TO:

INT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE -- KAFKA'S OFFICE -- DAY

Kafka at his desk. Files. Forms. Stamp. Signature. Date. His pen moves through official language without pause.

INT. KAFKA'S BEDROOM -- NIGHT

Same hand. Same pen. A notebook instead of a file.

He writes in a notebook. The handwriting is smaller now, more urgent. He pauses. Crosses out a line. Writes again. The lamp burns low.

INT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE -- KAFKA'S OFFICE -- DAY

A COLLEAGUE deposits a new stack of files on Kafka's desk. Kafka nods. Opens the top file.

Inside: a photograph of a machine. Belt, teeth, guard plate, grease-pencil marks in the margin.

INT. KAFKA'S BEDROOM -- NIGHT

Kafka writes. Faster now. He reaches the edge of the page, goes back, strikes a word, keeps going.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

KAFKA (V.O.)
As Gregor Samsa awoke one morning from uneasy dreams, he found himself transformed in his bed into a---

He stops with the nib hovering over the page. Looks at what he has written.

He writes the word.

CUT TO:

INT. TEXTILE FACTORY -- DAY

Noise. Machines. WORKERS at looms and presses. Kafka moves through the factory floor with a clipboard, accompanied by a reluctant FACTORY FOREMAN.

The machines are enormous and loud. Workers feed material into them without taking their eyes off the moving teeth.

FOREMAN
(shouting over the noise)
Everything is in order, as you can see. All guards in place. All regulations followed.

Kafka stops at a press. Examines the guard mechanism. It is loose. One bolt is missing entirely. He makes a note on his clipboard.

FOREMAN
That's nothing. We've ordered the replacement.

KAFKA
When?

FOREMAN
Recently.

KAFKA
The incident report from February says the same thing. ``Replacement ordered.'' It's now September.

The foreman's expression hardens.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

FOREMAN
Dr. Kafka, with respect, you're a lawyer. You sit in an office. You don't understand the realities of---

KAFKA
I understand the gap between this guard and the press bed is forty-two millimeters.
A human finger is approximately eighteen millimeters in diameter.
I understand your workers are asked to bet, every hour of every shift, that their attention will never waver.

A pause. The machines roar around them.

KAFKA
I'll note the bolt has not been replaced. The report will be filed by Friday.

He moves on. The foreman watches him go.

A WORKER at a nearby station --- a woman, middle-aged, hands quick and careful --- glances at Kafka as he passes. He glances back. Then she turns to the loom before the thread can slip.

INT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE -- KAFKA'S OFFICE -- LATER

Kafka at his desk. He opens the Kraus file. Inside: the medical photograph. A worker's hand. Two stumps where fingers were.

He studies it. Then closes the file and reaches for the inspection form.

CUT TO:

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

INT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE -- MARSCHNER'S OFFICE -- DAY

A larger office. Leather chairs. A window with a view. Marschner behind his desk, collar loosened, Board memoranda spread over a plate holding half an untouched sandwich. Kafka stands.

MARSCHNER
The Kraus report was exemplary. Your inspection findings forced a settlement in two days. I'm recommending you for senior assessor. Larger office, supervisory responsibility, a raise.

Kafka's eyes go first to the corner window, then to the half sandwich gone cold on Marschner's plate.

MARSCHNER
Office twenty-seven. Corner window. Door that shuts. One clerk who will fear you a little.

Marschner opens a drawer, takes out a brass key on a paper tag marked `27,' and sets it on the desk between them.

MARSCHNER
Take it. See how it feels in your pocket.

Kafka picks up the key. It is small, ordinary, heavier than it looks.

KAFKA
Heavier than the files.

MARSCHNER
It gets heavier. Then you stop noticing.

KAFKA
I appreciate your confidence, Director.

MARSCHNER
You've earned it.

KAFKA
I'd like to decline.

Marschner stares at him.

MARSCHNER
Decline.

KAFKA
The additional hours. The meetings. My current position leaves me a part of the day that is still mine.

MARSCHNER
Time for what? You never leave before dusk as it is.

MARSCHNER
If you've found a part of the day this building can't take, keep it.

MARSCHNER
You're the most competent man in this building and you want to stay in a box office reading claim files.

KAFKA
(a faint smile)
The files are honest. A machine takes a hand and says so plainly. I find that restful.

KAFKA
If I take the key, I will still be here at midnight.

Marschner shakes his head and lets the document fall closed on his desk. He glances once at the untouched sandwich, then back at Kafka.

Kafka sets the key back on the desk. It lies between them. Marschner's hand stays on the closed file. Kafka's stays at his side.

MARSCHNER
The offer stands. If you change your mind.

Kafka nods and leaves. In the corridor, he exhales only when Marschner's door shuts behind him.

CUT TO:

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

EXT. PRAGUE -- CHARLES BRIDGE -- LATE AFTERNOON

Kafka and Brod walk. The bridge is beautiful in the failing light. The saints on their pedestals look down with stone patience.

BROD
You refuse promotion. You refuse publishers. You refuse everything. Do you mean to disappoint both careers equally, or is one getting a head start?

KAFKA
It saves time.

BROD
You have three stories --- three --- as good as anything being written in German. In any language. The best short prose in Europe is sitting in your desk drawer.

KAFKA
They're sitting in my desk drawer because they're not finished.

BROD
They are as finished as you will ever let them be. And once they're written --- Franz, listen to me --- once they're written, they don't belong to you. They belong to whoever reads them.

KAFKA
That's the terrifying part.

BROD
That's the point of literature.

KAFKA
Writing is one thing.
Handing it to strangers is another.

They keep walking. Kafka trails two fingers along the cold stone parapet. Below them, the river works under the arches in the failing light.

KAFKA
All day at the Institute I wait for night. Then night comes and I miss the office.

BROD
That isn't an argument against writing.

KAFKA
No. It's an argument against me.

Kafka looks at him, then away to the river.

KAFKA
You're a good friend.

BROD
I know. It's what I'm good for.

KAFKA
It's not a small one.

They walk. The light fades. The saints on the bridge darken into silhouettes.

CUT TO:

INT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE -- CORRIDOR -- LATE AFTERNOON

End of the day. The building is emptying. Kafka walks down a long corridor toward the exit. His footsteps echo on the stone floor.

The corridor is ordinary. Doors on either side. Small brass plates with numbers.

He passes door 14. Door 15. Door 16. He should already be at the stairs.

The next brass plate reads KR-1742/11. The next: W-803/9. Claim numbers.

Kafka stops. Somewhere out of sight: a typewriter carriage snaps, then a saw catches on wood, then silence.

He looks behind him. The corridor stretches back, identical. No stairs.

He turns forward and walks faster. More doors. More numbers. One brass plate reads: ALTSTÄDTER RING 6 --- his father's

shop address. Then it reads KR-2201/4 again.

Then: the exit. Glass doors. Streetlight through the panes. A tram bell outside.

Kafka pushes through the doors into the evening air.

He stands on the steps and looks back through the glass. Inside: a short corridor ending where it should.

He adjusts his hat. Walks down the steps. Goes home.

FADE TO BLACK.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

III. THE WOMEN

PRAGUE, AUGUST 1912

INT. MAX BROD'S APARTMENT -- EVENING

A warm, crowded apartment. Brod's family and friends talking over one another, reaching for bread, refilling glasses.

Kafka sits at the edge of it with a glass he has barely touched.

The bell. BROD crosses to the door. FELICE BAUER, 25, steps in with a mutual friend, removing her gloves as she enters. Practical dress. Direct eyes. She glances once at the mantel clock, more out of habit than worry.

Brod makes introductions.

BROD
Felice, Franz Kafka. Insurance Institute by day. Trouble by night.

Felice extends her hand. Kafka takes it. Her grip is firm; his is brief.

FELICE
What do you write?

KAFKA
Stories. Short ones. About things going wrong.

FELICE
For whom?

KAFKA
Usually the man who thought he understood the room.

FELICE
I work for a dictation machine company in Berlin. The Parlograph.

KAFKA
A machine that records the human voice.

FELICE
And plays it back. For business correspondence.

KAFKA
A machine that remembers what one says. That's indecent.

Felice takes back her hand and keeps looking at him.

FELICE
In Berlin we call it useful.

Kafka looks at her a second too long.

CUT TO:

INT. KAFKA'S BEDROOM -- NIGHT

Kafka at his desk. A blank sheet where stories usually begin. Tonight it is a letter.

KAFKA (V.O.)
Dear Fräulein Bauer --- Do you even remember me? I am the thin man who sat across from you at Max Brod's table and who, piece by piece, passed you photographs of a trip to Thalia, which you were kind enough to look at.

He writes three lines, tears the page in half, starts again.

INT. FELICE'S APARTMENT -- BERLIN -- DAY

A tidy apartment. Felice stands at a small desk in her hat and jacket, reading Kafka's letter before leaving for work.

She reads the last line again. One glove comes off. Then the hat. She sits back down and writes two quick pages before putting it on again.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

INT. PARLOGRAPH OFFICE -- BERLIN -- DAY

A modern office. Desks. Typewriters. Filing trays. A dictation machine on a demonstration table: polished metal, cylinder, mouthpiece.

Felice moves through it with brisk authority. Two YOUNG CLERKS trail her with order forms. A SALESMAN struggles with the machine's mouthpiece.

SALESMAN
Fräulein Bauer, the Klein demonstration is at three and the cylinder keeps catching.

FELICE
The cylinder is not catching. Herr Klein is turning it incorrectly. The machine is not temperamental. He is.

She takes the machine, adjusts one small screw, sets the cylinder, and speaks into the mouthpiece with efficient clarity.

FELICE
Letter to Hirsch & Co. Shipment confirmed for Thursday. Please stop telegraphing as if stationery were perishable.

The cylinder turns smoothly. The salesman stares. The young clerks hide smiles.

A MESSENGER brings in the afternoon post. Felice sorts it standing up. Bills. Orders. Circulars. One envelope from Prague in Kafka's careful hand. She pauses almost imperceptibly. Puts it aside. Finishes with the orders first.

INT. KAFKA'S BEDROOM -- NIGHT

Another night. Another letter. The stack beside him has grown thick enough to need a paperweight.

KAFKA (V.O.)
I want to know what you eat for breakfast. Whether you sleep well. What the view from your office window looks like at four in the afternoon. If these are absurd questions, forgive me. They do not feel small here.

He seals the letter, adds it to the stack, then pulls a fresh page toward him before the wax has cooled.

INT. FELICE'S APARTMENT -- BERLIN -- EVENING

Felice reads his latest letter at her kitchen table while eating dinner. Halfway through, she puts down her fork. Reads the same paragraph again.

The potatoes go cold. She folds the letter once, unfolds it, and keeps reading.

CUT TO:

INT. ASKANISCHER HOF HOTEL -- BERLIN -- DAY

BERLIN, 1914

A hotel meeting room. Wallpaper, water glasses, a long table too formal for an engagement.

Kafka sits on one side with Brod. Opposite: Felice between FRAU BAUER and ERNA. GRETE BLOCH at the far end, watchful.

Kafka wears his best suit. His hands are flat on the table.

FRAU BAUER
Herr Kafka. We appreciate your interest in our Felice.

KAFKA
Thank you, Frau Bauer.

FRAU BAUER
You have a position at the Insurance Institute in Prague, I understand.

KAFKA
Yes. A permanent position.

FRAU BAUER
And what are your plans for advancement?

Kafka glances at Felice. She gives him the smallest nod: answer well.

KAFKA
The Institute is stable. The salary is adequate.

FRAU BAUER
That was not my question.

KAFKA
I have not pursued advancement aggressively.

A pause. Under the table, Felice's hand moves toward his. She stops just short.

FRAU BAUER
And where would my daughter live? In Prague?

KAFKA
That was the idea.

FRAU BAUER
Alone with you?

KAFKA
No. At first, probably with my family until---

The room changes temperature. Felice closes her eyes once. Brod stares at the table.

FRAU BAUER
And the writing?

KAFKA
At night.

FRAU BAUER
So my daughter lives in your parents' apartment while you write through the night.

KAFKA
Temporarily.

FRAU BAUER
Felice works hard. She expects order.

FELICE
(quietly firm)
Mother.

Frau Bauer stops. The room breathes.

Brod watches his friend. Grete watches Felice.

KAFKA
Frau Bauer. Your concerns are not unfair.

That lands badly. He starts again.

KAFKA
I can promise your daughter seriousness. I cannot promise comfort.

Silence. Frau Bauer looks at Felice. Felice keeps her face still. Kafka looks back down at his hands.

Grete lowers her eyes. She has heard enough.

CUT TO:

INT. RESTAURANT -- BERLIN -- EVENING

A private dining room. Bigger now: both families, friends, Brod, too many glasses, too much approval.

Kafka sits near the center of the table, smiling already before anyone speaks.

Across from him, Hermann is in his element --- booming, charming, taking up space. Julie watches Franz instead of the room.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

HERMANN
(raising his glass)
My son! The doctor of law, the insurance man, and now a fiancé! Julie, can you believe it?

Laughter. Glasses lifted. Chairs shifting. Plates arriving.

Kafka raises his glass. Drinks. His hand is steady. His eyes are not.

Under the table, Felice takes his hand. He lets her. Her hand is warm and certain. His is cold.

CLOSE ON KAFKA'S FACE as the conversation swirls around him. Knife on plate. Laughter. Wine being poured. Hermann's laugh.

The sounds begin to align. Fork on china. A cough. Wine into glass. Another fork. Then a stamp inside his head.

Kafka's smile holds. Too correct.

FELICE
(whispering)
Are you all right?

KAFKA
(the smile never wavering)
Couldn't be better.

Felice looks at him, then back to her plate. She lets the answer stand.

HERMANN
(to Frau Bauer)
He'll settle now. You'll see. He needs a wife. Structure. Purpose. A woman like your Felice to keep him in line.

FRAU BAUER
Felice is very organized. She runs the entire Berlin office.

HERMANN
(delighted)
There, you see? My boy has finally found some appetite!

He takes a dinner roll, tears it in half, eats, keeps talking.

Kafka opens his mouth. Something rises in him --- a sentence, an objection, the beginning of a door opening. Then it dies. His jaw closes. He sets down his fork.

Felice sees it. The thing that almost happened and didn't. She files it away without knowing what it was.

Later. Dessert. Coffee. The conversation has softened into the comfortable murmur of people who are satisfied with how things have gone.

Kafka excuses himself. Goes to the restroom.

INT. RESTAURANT -- RESTROOM -- CONTINUOUS

He stands at the sink. Runs cold water. Holds his hands under it. Looks at himself in the mirror.

The smile stays on his face two seconds longer than it should. Then it drops away.

He grips the sink. Straightens his tie. Rebuilds the smile. Returns to the table.

The dinner continues. He sits. Felice squeezes his hand. He squeezes back.

CUT TO:

SIX WEEKS LATER

INT. HOTEL ROOM -- BERLIN -- DAY

A small hotel room. Neutral furniture. On the table between them: a neat stack of letters in Kafka's hand. Beside Felice's chair: a leather office satchel and a return train ticket.

Felice sits by the window in a dark dress, straight-backed. Kafka sits opposite, hands locked together.

FELICE
Grete showed me your letters.

Kafka says nothing. Felice unties the ribbon around the stack.

FELICE
In mine, you ask for marriage. In hers, you explain why it would destroy you.

FELICE
You were very eloquent about it. You're always eloquent about what you can't do.

KAFKA
(very quietly)
Felice---

FELICE
No. Let me finish.

FELICE
I kept thinking the letters were the difficult part. They weren't. They were the part you liked.

Kafka looks at his hands.

KAFKA
I wanted it to work.

FELICE
Work is what a man says when he wants credit for trying.

She slips the engagement ring from her finger and places it squarely on the top letter.

FELICE
I came here from the office for this. I'll go back there after.

FELICE
You wanted a woman in Berlin who stayed where you left her. Answering when addressed. Waiting when required.

FELICE
The real me was opening the office at nine, answering telegrams, missing supper, sleeping badly. Your letters wanted me sitting still with time for them.

KAFKA
That's not fair.

FELICE
No. Fair would have been telling me sooner.

She stands. Puts on her coat. Buttons it carefully.

FELICE
Goodbye, Franz.

She moves to the door. Stops.

FELICE
You prefer wanting a thing to having it.

She leaves. The door closes. The room is silent.

Kafka does not move. The ring sits on the letters between them, where she left it.

CUT TO:

INT. INSURANCE INSTITUTE -- KAFKA'S OFFICE -- MORNING

Kafka at his desk in a fresh collar and the same dark suit. He has not slept enough to hide it.

He opens the top file. Inside: a follow-up report on the Kraus sawmill. A second worker injured. Different hand. Same machine. The replacement bolt has been removed again.

Kafka reads the report. Reads it again. His face hardens.

A knock. Marschner enters with a telegram already unfolded, coat still on as if three other doors have already kept him from going home.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

MARSCHNER
The owner says the worker ignored posted instructions. His counsel says we're confusing accident insurance with moral theater.

KAFKA
A second man has lost the use of his hand to the same machine after a direct order.

MARSCHNER
I know what the file says. By supper the Board will call it carelessness with witnesses.

Kafka stands. The gesture is abrupt enough to surprise even him.

KAFKA
Then close the line.
Inspect every guard assembly in every Kraus mill.
Personal liability if one bolt is gone.

MARSCHNER
Good. Now write it so Vienna can sign it.

Kafka sits again. Pulls a clean sheet toward him.

KAFKA
Very well. `Repeated noncompliance creating foreseeable injury.'

MARSCHNER
Yes. Cold enough to survive a meeting.

Marschner watches him begin. Some private satisfaction under the worry.

MARSCHNER
By noon, Kafka. Before the owner has time to become sympathetic.

He leaves. Kafka writes. Ink catches at the nib. He keeps going.

The clock ticks. He does not look up.

CUT TO:

INT. KAFKA'S BEDROOM -- NIGHT

Kafka at his desk. The lamp burns.

On the desk: Felice's letters, tied again with ribbon.

He opens his notebook. Writes.

He gets one line down. Stops. Tears out the page.

Through the wall: his father coughing in his sleep. Kafka waits for it to stop. It does not.

He turns the page. Starts again. This time it is not a letter and not a diary entry.

The words come fast.

He writes until the lamp burns low. Outside the window, Prague is dark. The spires of the Old Town are barely visible.

The pen keeps moving. The coughing goes on behind the wall.

CUT TO:

PRAGUE / VIENNA, 1920

INT. CAFÉ -- PRAGUE -- DAY

Post arrives at Kafka's café table. One envelope from Vienna, in an unfamiliar hand. He opens it.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

MILENA (V.O.)
Dear Herr Kafka --- I have begun translating
your story ``The Stoker'' into Czech. I must tell you
your German is not what I expected. It is not
the German of a German. It is the German of someone
who has invented a language inside the language.
It is exact and strange. I cannot stop reading it.

Kafka reads it once, then again more slowly. His coffee goes cold beside his hand.

INT. MILENA'S APARTMENT -- VIENNA -- DAY

MILENA JESENSKÁ, 24, works at a desk crowded with Kafka's pages, a Czech dictionary, a newspaper proof, and a cup gone cold. She pencils a sentence into the margin, checks the dictionary, recopies it cleanly, then tears the top half from another page and starts again.

ERNST POLAK passes through the room with his coat already on, an opened envelope in hand. He glances at the newspaper proof, then at Kafka's pages beneath it.

POLAK
Tribuna wants the column before four. Your Prague author can wait.

MILENA
The column will go at four. He won't.

Polak moves on. She keeps working.

INT. KAFKA'S BEDROOM -- NIGHT

Kafka writes to Milena. No crossing out. One page, then another, before the first has dried.

KAFKA (V.O.)
I am afraid of everything, Milena. Of the dark, of the light, of what I might write, of what I might not write, of you, of not-you, of the distance between Prague and Vienna, which is too small to protect me and too large to cross.

CUT TO:

EXT. VIENNA -- CAFÉ TERRACE -- AFTERNOON

Summer. An outdoor café. Linden trees. The sounds of Vienna: horses, trams, the particular music of a city that believes in pleasure.

Kafka waits at a table, aligning the spoon with the saucer, then misaligning it again.

Milena arrives with a pencil-marked translation page folded in her hand, a reporter's notebook under her arm, and ink on two fingers. She sets the page beside his cup, checks the café clock, sits, and says nothing until he looks up.

MILENA
You look exactly like someone who should have stayed in Prague. Sit down. I have forty minutes before I hand in copy, so if you are going to be fascinating, do it quickly.

She sets the translation page between them, flags a sentence with her nail.

KAFKA
Then I have traveled correctly.

MILENA
I brought your page. You use five words where anyone reasonable would use eight and somehow it creates more trouble, not less. I have been fighting this sentence since Tuesday.

KAFKA
Trouble is one of the cheaper effects.

MILENA
Your stories make trouble. Your letters make it worse --- by the second page they have already started leaving the room. I keep translating them anyway because the German is so clean I can hear my own language underneath it, which is infuriating and also probably why I wrote to you in the first place.

Kafka reaches for his coffee. The spoon hits the cup. Milena notices, does not rescue him.

KAFKA
Milena. I should tell you something.

MILENA
You are going to tell me not to expect anything human from this.
Don't. I am a journalist. I expect copy and deadlines
and that men will disappoint me on schedule.

KAFKA
I'm afraid. And I keep writing to you.
Maybe it's the same thing.

MILENA
Of course it is. You disappear very early and keep signing your name. I noticed on page one.

He looks at her. This time he does not look away first.

CUT TO:

EXT. VIENNA -- PARK -- LATE AFTERNOON

They walk. Close, but not touching.

KAFKA
You're married.

MILENA
Poorly.

KAFKA
And I am---

MILENA
You are what? Finish the sentence. I finish mine.

KAFKA
I am significantly worse in person.

MILENA
Yes. Letters let you arrange yourself. In person you are nervous and your collar is crooked and you have not once looked at the trees, which are beautiful. Why are you here?

He stops walking. Looks at her.

KAFKA
Because with you I thought I might fail in person and remain anyway.

She takes his hand. He lets her.

MILENA
Then fail here. Stay. I have nowhere to be until four.

Traffic and voices continue around them. For once, Kafka does not retreat.

It lasts only a moment. A moment is more than he expected.

EXT. VIENNA -- TRAIN PLATFORM -- EVENING

Steam. Porters. Calls from conductors. Kafka and Milena stand beside his carriage. He has not boarded yet.

Milena holds a folded timetable and one corrected proof page from his story. She presses both into his hand.

MILENA
Ernst is in Dresden until Tuesday. There is a furnished room above my printer's shop on Štěpánská --- bad wallpaper, good lock, the tram stops outside. If you want an actual scandal, it is available and it has an address.

KAFKA
You make catastrophe sound municipal.

MILENA
I am a journalist. Everything is municipal. I am offering you a room, not a metaphor.

He looks at her. The noise of the station gives them privacy by refusing it.

KAFKA
Prague is difficult.

MILENA
Prague is your alibi. Prague has always been your alibi. I am standing on a platform in Vienna and I am asking about you.

KAFKA
If you came closer, I would bring the whole apparatus with me. Fear. Delay. My father's voice. The rest of the furniture.

MILENA
Franz, you already bring it. Only by post. At least in person I could see your face while you explain why you can't stay.

A whistle. Passengers begin boarding.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

MILENA
Do you know what I like least about your letters? They arrive having understood everything except whether you actually mean to live.

That lands. He cannot answer quickly enough.

MILENA
Don't write tonight.
Let one thing happen without being turned into pages.

The conductor calls again. Kafka steps onto the carriage, then turns back.

KAFKA
Milena---

MILENA
I know. That's the trouble.

The train starts. Kafka remains at the door as the platform moves away. Milena does not wave.

FADE TO BLACK.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

IV. THE ILLNESS

PRAGUE, AUGUST 1917

INT. KAFKA'S BEDROOM -- NIGHT

Three in the morning. Kafka wakes coughing. He sits up in the narrow bed, hand pressed to his mouth.

When the coughing stops, he looks at his hand. The moonlight through the window shows the dark stain clearly.

He turns on the lamp. Looks at his hand more carefully. It is unmistakable.

He gets up. Goes to the washstand. Rinses his hand. Rinses it again. The water in the basin turns pink.

He stands there for a long time. Then he does something unexpected: he smiles. A strange, private smile --- the smile of a man who has just received confirmation of something he has always suspected.

CUT TO:

INT. DOCTOR'S OFFICE -- PRAGUE -- DAY

A consulting room. Clean. Clinical. DR. MÜHLSTEIN, 50s, a careful man with careful hands, sits across from Kafka. Between them, on the desk: an X-ray plate. The white shadow on the lung is clearly visible.

DR. MÜHLSTEIN
The left lung, primarily. There is involvement of the bronchial tissue. The hemorrhage you described is consistent with---

KAFKA
Tuberculosis.

DR. MÜHLSTEIN
Yes.

A pause. The doctor waits for the reaction --- the shock, the denial, the questions. Kafka provides none of these.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

KAFKA
What do you recommend?

DR. MÜHLSTEIN
Rest. Mountain air, if possible. A sanatorium. Your diet must be carefully managed. And your work---

KAFKA
My work at the Institute?

DR. MÜHLSTEIN
Must be reduced. Ideally suspended. Your body needs---

KAFKA
My body and I have never been on good terms. I don't expect a reconciliation now.

The doctor studies him.

DR. MÜHLSTEIN
Herr Kafka. This is serious.

KAFKA
(quietly, almost gently)
I know, Doctor. I only thought it would stay on the page.

CUT TO:

EXT. PRAGUE -- SMALL PARK -- AFTERNOON

Kafka and Ottla on a bench. Autumn. Leaves falling with slow deliberation.

KAFKA
Tuberculosis. The left lung.

Ottla is silent. She takes his arm. Pulls him close. He lets her.

OTTLA
You're coming to Zürau. The cottage. Fresh air. No one to bother you.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

KAFKA
Father will say I'm being dramatic.

OTTLA
He can say whatever he likes.

Her tone is final. She is, in this moment, the strongest person in Kafka's life.

CUT TO:

EXT. ZÜRAU -- VILLAGE -- DAY

A small village in northwest Bohemia. Fields. Low stone walls. The extraordinary quiet of a place where the principal sounds are wind and animal.

Kafka walks a dirt path. He is wearing simpler clothes than Prague requires. He breathes the country air with the careful attention of a man who has been told his breathing now has administrative significance.

INT. OTTLA'S COTTAGE -- ZÜRAU -- DAY

A simple room. A bed, a desk, a window facing the fields. Ottla has made it clean and warm. Kafka sets down his bag.

Ottla comes in after him carrying kindling under one arm, her skirt hem muddy, her sleeves rolled. This refuge has not appeared by miracle.

He goes to the desk. Touches it. Sits in the chair.

Through the window: fields, sky, the slow movement of clouds. No insurance forms. No father's voice. No Prague.

He opens his notebook. Writes.

KAFKA (V.O.)
A cage went in search of a bird.

He writes. In Zürau, something happens to his prose. It becomes shorter. Sharper. The aphorisms he produces here are like stones --- small, hard, irrefutable.

INT. OTTLA'S COTTAGE -- ZÜRAU -- EVENING

Kafka and Ottla eat a simple dinner. Bread. Cheese. Milk. Ottla cuts the cheese into two pieces, gives him the larger one, and pretends not to notice each time he stops chewing. When he pauses too long, she nudges the milk toward him without comment.

OTTLA
You're eating.

KAFKA
I'm negotiating with the bread. It's a different thing.

OTTLA
The country air suits you.

KAFKA
The quiet suits me. Let the air take the credit.

OTTLA
The air and I milked two cows before dawn, so I'd like equal credit.

She looks at him. Directly.

OTTLA
You know he asks about you. Every day. He asks Mother to read your letters aloud at dinner.

KAFKA
That sounds right. He likes me better on paper.

Ottla shakes her head, but one corner of her mouth gives way. She tears off another piece of bread and sets it on his plate without looking at him.

CUT TO:

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

EXT. ZÜRAU -- VILLAGE ROAD -- AFTERNOON

A hired car on the dirt road. Out of place among the fields. HERMANN KAFKA climbs out, overcoat, city shoes, carrying a large wicker basket heavy enough to shift his weight.

He looks at the village. The mud. The sky. The absolute absence of commerce.

INT. OTTLA'S COTTAGE -- ZÜRAU -- CONTINUOUS

Kafka sits at the desk, notebook open. A knock. Ottla answers. Her face changes.

Hermann fills the doorframe. He sets the basket on the table. It lands with authority.

HERMANN
Your mother packed it. Smoked meat. That cheese you used to eat. Real bread, not whatever the country calls bread.

He looks at his son. At the narrow bed, the bare walls, the desk with its notebooks. At Kafka, who is thinner than the last time they stood in the same room.

HERMANN
You look---

He stops himself. Starts again.

HERMANN
The air is supposed to help.

KAFKA
It does help.

HERMANN
Good. Eat the cheese. Your mother asked three times if I had the cheese.

He sits in the only other chair. It is too small for him. His knees nearly touch the desk. The room, which was enough for Kafka, contracts around Hermann the way all rooms do.

Silence. Hermann looks at the notebooks on the desk. Does not ask. Looks out the window at the fields instead.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

HERMANN
What do you do here all day?

KAFKA
I rest. I walk. I write a little.

HERMANN
You could rest in Prague.
Your mother would cook for you prop-
erly. Not---

He gestures at the cottage. At all of it.

KAFKA
The quiet helps, Father.

HERMANN
Quiet. In Prague there is quiet.
Close the door.

Kafka says nothing. Hermann opens the basket. Unwraps the cheese. Sets it on the table. Unwraps the bread. Cuts two thick slices and pushes one toward his son.

HERMANN
Eat.

Kafka picks up the bread. Takes a small bite. Hermann watches until it is swallowed, then eats his own slice in three bites.

For a moment they are just a father and a son eating bread in a small room. It is almost ordinary. It is almost enough.

HERMANN
You need weight. The doctor said
weight.

KAFKA
Thank you for coming.

Hermann looks at him. Something passes across his face --- not tenderness, but the shadow of what tenderness would look like in a man who has never had the word for it.

HERMANN
Your mother worries.

He stands. The chair gives back its space.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

HERMANN
Eat the cheese, Franz. The whole thing. Don't write about it, eat it.

He puts on his hat. Stops at the door. Turns back.

HERMANN
The shop is fine. In case you were wondering.

KAFKA
I was wondering.

Hermann leaves. The hired car starts. Kafka watches it until the road dust settles.

On the table: the bread, the cheese, the smoked meat. The basket. The notebooks pushed to one side to make room for it.

Ottla comes in from the back. Looks at the food. Looks at her brother.

OTTLA
He came all this way?

KAFKA
He brought cheese.

Ottla picks up the knife and cuts the cheese properly. Neither of them says what the visit meant. Neither of them needs to.

CUT TO:

INT. OTTLA'S COTTAGE -- ZÜRAU -- AFTERNOON

Rain against the window. Ottla comes in with the post and a pair of muddy boots in her hand. One envelope bears the seal of the Workers' Accident Insurance Institute.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

OTTLA
Your office can track livestock now.

Kafka takes the envelope. Opens it. Inside: a short note from Marschner and a thin file tied with string. KRAUS SAWMILLS.

INSERT: ``Kafka --- Kraus has appealed the compensation order and the mandatory inspections. The Board wants compromise. I would prefer accuracy. If you have strength for a memorandum, I need it. Not only on Kraus. On guard standards generally. If we can make one owner's fraud read like an administrative problem, we may force them to fix more than one mill. Marschner.''

Kafka reads. Coughs into his handkerchief. Reads again.

OTTLA
You don't have to answer that.

KAFKA
I know. That's why I will.

He sits at the desk. Opens the file. Inspection notes. A worker's statement. A factory owner's letter explaining that every precaution had been taken. He lays the worker's statement on top.

Kafka writes. Coughs into the handkerchief. Waits. Keeps writing. One adjective gets crossed out. A measurement replaces it.

He finishes the memorandum on Kraus. Pulls a second clean page toward him. At the top he writes: ``Minimum Guard Requirements for Circular Saws and Feed Cylinders.''

He numbers the hazards one by one. Missing guards. Feed speed. Distance of hands from blade. By the time he stops, Kraus's name appears only twice. He squares the pages and sets them aside.

Then he pulls a fresh stack of paper toward him. There is another case, older and unwinnable, for which no office exists.

CUT TO:

SCHELESEN, NOVEMBER 1919

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

INT. PENSION STÜDL -- KAFKA'S ROOM -- NIGHT

A small room in a pension in the countryside. Kafka at the desk. Written pages to his left. Blank paper to his right. The written pile is already thick.

KAFKA (V.O.)
Dearest Father --- You asked me recently why I maintain
that I am afraid of you. As usual, I was unable
to think of any answer, partly because the basis
of my fear is so great that it goes beyond
my power of speech and even my power of thought.

He writes without the usual delay. Dips the pen. Turns the page. Keeps going.

INT. PENSION STÜDL -- KAFKA'S ROOM -- LATER

Thirty pages. Forty. The lamp burns lower. A glass of water. A cup of coffee gone cold.

KAFKA (V.O.)
Sometimes I imagine the map of the world spread out and you stretched diagonally across it. And I feel as if I could consider living in only those regions that either are not covered by you or are not within your reach. And in keeping with the image I have of your magnitude, these regions are not many and not very comforting.

He drinks. His hand trembles once. He waits for it to steady, then keeps writing.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

INT. PENSION STÜDL -- KAFKA'S ROOM -- LATER STILL

Kafka writes. Outside, the village is dark and silent.

Fifty pages. Sixty. The handwriting stays small, exact. By dawn the stack has outgrown the blotter.

KAFKA (V.O.)
My writing was all about you; all I did there, after all, was to bemoan what I could not bemoan upon your breast.
It was an intentionally long-drawn-out leave-taking from you, yet, although enforced by you, it did take its course in the direction determined by me.

He sets down the pen. Flexes his hand. Turns the whole stack over and reads from the beginning. The pages make a dry, official sound in the room.

At the end he sits very still. Then he ties the bundle with string, wraps it, and writes on the front: ``For Father.''

After a beat, he adds: ``Via Mother.''

CUT TO:

INT. KAFKA FAMILY APARTMENT -- HALLWAY -- AFTERNOON

Kafka stands in the hallway of the family apartment. The manuscript is in his hands, wrapped and tied. He faces his father's study door.

Through the door: the scratch of a pen on a ledger. The creak of Hermann's chair. A cough. The small domestic sounds of a man doing accounts.

Kafka's hand rises to the door handle. Touches it. The metal is cold.

He stands there. Ten seconds. Twenty. His hand on the handle. His father's breathing on the other side.

Inside the study, Hermann shifts his weight. The chair protests. A page turns.

Kafka's grip tightens. Then loosens. Then tightens again.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

From the kitchen, the sound of Julie filling the kettle. The small mercy of another person in the apartment.

Kafka takes his hand off the handle.

He stands in the hallway a moment longer. Then he turns and walks toward the kitchen, the manuscript still in his hands.

CUT TO:

INT. KAFKA FAMILY APARTMENT -- LIVING ROOM -- DAY

Kafka places the wrapped bundle in Julie's hands. She is startled by the weight.

JULIE
What is this?

KAFKA
A letter. Will you give it to Father?

Julie reads the front. Looks toward the bedroom door. Beyond it: Hermann snoring faintly in his afternoon sleep.

JULIE
Franz...

KAFKA
Please. He doesn't have to answer. I only need him to read it.

Julie sits with the bundle on her lap.

JULIE
(very quietly)
I can't give this to him, Franz.

KAFKA
Mother---

JULIE
I know what's in it without opening it.

JULIE
If I carry this into that room, he will hear accusation before he hears pain. You will hear mockery before you hear anything at all. By supper the whole apartment will be sick with it.

KAFKA
That's his problem.

JULIE
No. That's all of us. That's what a family is.

Kafka stares at the bundle in her lap.

KAFKA
You've carried things between us my whole life.

JULIE
Exactly. Which is why I won't carry this one.

KAFKA
(very quietly)
Then it was all for nothing.

JULIE
No. You finally said it. That is not nothing.

Kafka nods. He leaves the apartment.

Julie listens to his steps fade. Hermann snores in the next room. She opens her writing desk, places the bundle inside, and closes the drawer.

INT. KAFKA FAMILY APARTMENT -- DINING ROOM -- EVENING

Supper. Hermann at the head of the table. Julie serving soup. Franz's place has been laid and cleared again so quickly that the damp ring from the lifted bowl still darkens the cloth.

HERMANN
Any word from Franz?

JULIE
He is resting. The country air helps.

HERMANN
Good. Let it cure him of analysis. A man coughs once and suddenly the whole family becomes literature.

Julie sets down the bread basket. Says nothing.

HERMANN
Did he send another packet? He always writes too much when a postcard would do.

JULIE
Only a note.

Hermann eats. Julie watches the writing desk from across the room without appearing to.

HERMANN
Tell him to come to supper when he has appetite enough to eat like a man.

Julie lifts the extra spoon from beside Franz's place setting and carries it back to the sideboard. Later. Hermann rises and crosses to the writing desk for the household ledger. Julie is up before he can touch the top drawer.

HERMANN
Where is it?

JULIE
Lower drawer. I moved it.

She opens the lower drawer, hands him the ledger, and closes it again. Hermann returns to the table, satisfied. Julie keeps her hand on the top drawer until he looks down at the ledger and not at her.

CUT TO:

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

INT. KAFKA FAMILY APARTMENT -- KITCHEN -- MORNING

Early. Before Hermann wakes. Julie at the stove. Ottla enters with a paper bag from the market --- bread, eggs. She sets it on the counter without being asked.

Julie takes the eggs, cracks two into a pan. Ottla hangs her coat, rolls her sleeves, starts slicing the bread. They work around each other with the ease of women who have shared this kitchen for twenty years.

OTTLA
You look tired.

JULIE
I've looked tired since 1898. It's practically a feature.

Ottla almost smiles. She puts the kettle on.

OTTLA
How is the new girl at the shop?

JULIE
Hopeless with the ribbon but good with customers. Your father trains her the way he trains everyone --- volume and repetition.

OTTLA
The two things he's never short of.

Julie slides an egg onto a plate and sets it in front of Ottla.

JULIE
Franz left something with me. For your father. A letter.

OTTLA
How long?

JULIE
A hundred pages.

Ottla stops slicing.

OTTLA
And you kept it.

JULIE
I put it in the writing desk. Top drawer.

OTTLA
Good.

JULIE
Good?

OTTLA
If you'd given it to Father, he'd have read ten pages, called it ingratitude, and used the rest to light the stove. You know that.

JULIE
I know that.

A pause. Ottla pours two cups of coffee. Sets one in front of her mother.

JULIE
Thirty years of carrying things between them. And he asks me to carry the one thing that would break.

OTTLA
That's why he asked you. Because you'd know not to.

Julie looks at her daughter. Something passes between them --- not revelation, but recognition. Two women who have lived inside the same man's gravity and found different ways to stand.

JULIE
When did you get so sharp?

OTTLA
The farm. Animals don't explain. You watch what they do.

Julie laughs. A real laugh, quiet and surprised.

JULIE
Eat your egg.

OTTLA
You eat yours.

JULIE
I'm not hungry.

OTTLA
You and Franz.

That lands differently than Ottla intended. Julie picks up her fork.

From the bedroom: Hermann turning over. The bedsprings. The familiar sound of a large man deciding whether the day has earned his attention yet.

OTTLA
I'll talk to him.

JULIE
Be gentle.

OTTLA
I'm always gentle. I just don't look it.

She takes her coat and goes. Julie finishes the egg. Washes both plates. The drawer with the letter is three steps from where she stands. She does not look at it.

CUT TO:

EXT. PRAGUE -- VLTAVA RIVER EMBANKMENT -- AFTERNOON

Kafka and Ottla walk beside the river. Winter. Their breath hangs in the air.

OTTLA
Mother told me about the letter. And that she won't deliver it.

Kafka says nothing.

KAFKA
She was right not---

OTTLA
---not to. I know. She was useful. That's the word you want.

OTTLA
You wrote a hundred pages because paper doesn't interrupt. Then you gave them to Mother because she does.

KAFKA
If I'd put it in his hand---

OTTLA
He would have turned it into a scene. Yes. And you would have been in the scene. That's what you can't bear.

Kafka stops walking. Ottla stops with him.

OTTLA
You stood at his door, Franz. I know because I know you. And you walked away and gave it to Mother instead.

KAFKA
(very quietly)
Cruelest thing you've said to me.

OTTLA
I learned it from Father. I just say it to your face.

A long silence. The river moves.

KAFKA
You're right.

OTTLA
I know. I'm sorry.

She takes his arm. They walk. Two children of the same father, marked differently by the same wound.

CUT TO:

TATRANSKÉ MATLIARE, 1921

INT. SANATORIUM -- KAFKA'S ROOM -- DAY

Brod sits across from Kafka. Between them, on the table: a plate of food Kafka has barely touched and two cups of tea. Kafka is thinner. The sanatorium has given him regularity but not recovery. Brod has already cut one roll into smaller pieces and lined them up by Kafka's hand.

Brod reaches for his tea, picks up Kafka's cup by mistake, puts it back, picks up the right one, puts that back too. His hands want a task they cannot find.

BROD
You look --- well. You look well.

KAFKA
I look like a man who has been told to eat six times a day and manages three.

BROD
Three is better than two. Three is something.

KAFKA
Max. Spare me.

Brod deflates. Then tears off the smallest piece of bread, sets it by Kafka's hand, and only then pulls a journal from his bag.

BROD
I brought you --- here. The new issue. Page forty-three. Your story. It's extraordinary, Franz. The best thing in the---

Kafka takes the journal. Opens it. Finds his story. Reads the first line. His expression does something complicated --- pride and embarrassment and something like grief, all at once.

KAFKA
They misspelled ``Josefine.''

BROD
No one will care.

KAFKA
I care.

BROD
Of course you care. You're right. You're always right about this. Eat one bite and continue being right.

Kafka looks at him, irritated and grateful in the same glance. He takes the piece, eats it, swallows.

Brod's face changes. Serious now.

BROD
Franz. I need to ask you something.

KAFKA
About the manuscripts.

BROD
You have drawers full of unpublished work. Novels. Stories. Fragments. If anything were to---

KAFKA
If I were to die, you mean.

BROD
I didn't say that.

KAFKA
You were about to say it. Doctors say ``options'' when they mean they are running out of them.

Brod is quiet.

KAFKA
I've thought about it. I want them destroyed.

Brod stares at him.

BROD
You can't mean that.

KAFKA
They're unfinished. Unpublishable. Why would I want that kept?

BROD
Because it matters. Even the frag-
ments do.
It belongs to---

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

KAFKA
Don't say ``the world.'' The world didn't write them. I did. And I didn't finish them.

BROD
Literature is not a house. A half-finished novel by you is worth more than the complete works of---

KAFKA
Now you're flattering me. You've lost the argument.

A pause. The tension between them is real --- not hostility, but the friction of two men who love each other and disagree about something fundamental. Brod believes the work belongs to humanity. Kafka believes the work belongs to the fire.

BROD
I'll respect your wishes.

KAFKA
You say that the way I say ``I'll sleep earlier.'' Neither of us means it.

Brod reaches across the table and puts his hand on Kafka's. A gesture of friendship so plain and unadorned that Kafka does not know how to receive it. He sits with Brod's hand on his and looks out the window at the mountains and says nothing.

CUT TO:

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

INT. SANATORIUM -- VARIOUS -- DAY / NIGHT

A sequence. Clinical, rhythmic, like the stations of an administrative process:

Kafka on a scale. The NURSE records the number. It is lower than last week.

Kafka at a meal table. Soup, bread, milk. He eats the bread. Sips the milk. Pushes the soup away.

Kafka in a chair on a terrace, wrapped in blankets. Mountain air. Other PATIENTS nearby, similarly wrapped. No one speaks.

Kafka coughing. Into a handkerchief. He folds it without looking at it.

A letter arrives. Institute stationery. Kafka opens it at the terrace table.

INSERT: ``Kafka --- the young man from the waiting room, the belt-press case. You will be glad to know his claim was approved in full. He is working again, left-handed, at a different factory. Your wording on the form made the difference. --- Marschner.''

Kafka reads it. Folds it once. Reads it again.

He picks up his notebook. The handwriting is the same. The hand that writes it is thinner.

CUT TO:

INT. SANATORIUM -- CORRIDOR -- NIGHT

Kafka walks the corridor. Late. Lights dimmed. Behind the closed doors: coughing. The universal sound of the sanatorium at night.

The rhythm tightens. Not random. Coordinated. Stamps landing on forms. A carriage returning. Claims being processed.

A door opens. For half a second, the room behind it is not a hospital room. It is a dining room. White cloth. Candles. A large man sitting at the head of the table.

Then it is a hospital room again. A NURSE with a chart.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

NURSE
Herr Kafka? Back to bed.

He goes.

FADE TO BLACK.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

V. THE FIRE

MÜRITZ, BALTIC COAST, JULY 1923

EXT. SUMMER CAMP -- MÜRITZ -- DAY

A holiday camp for Eastern European Jewish children. Simple wooden buildings near the sea. The sound of children playing. Yiddish, Hebrew, German mingling in the summer air.

Kafka, 40 now and visibly fragile, sits on a bench in the shade. He is watching the children with an expression of such gentle attention that it borders on pain.

DORA DIAMANT, 25, comes out of the camp kitchen carrying a tray of fish and black bread. Dark-haired. Direct. Built for work, not display.

She sees the thin, dark-eyed man on the bench turning a fish over in his fingers, checking again for bones while one of the smaller boys already reaches for it.

DORA
(approaching)
Don't give him that. He'll swallow a bone and they'll blame the kitchen.

Kafka looks up.

KAFKA
Then you've arrived in time to save us both.

DORA
Him certainly. You, we'll see.

She takes the fish from his hand, strips the bones out with quick, practiced fingers, and gives it to the boy.

DORA
Eat slowly. Once in your life.

The boy runs off. Dora looks at Kafka's empty hands.

KAFKA
You're from the kitchen?

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

DORA
Dora Diamant.
From Będzin, Poland.
Kitchen, laundry, occasional rescue work.

KAFKA
Franz Kafka. Prague.
My doctor prescribed sea air and obedience.

DORA
And have you disappointed him yet?

KAFKA
Continuously.

She laughs. Not politely, but with recognition. Kafka watches her a beat too long.

CUT TO:

EXT. BEACH -- MÜRITZ -- EVENING

They walk along the shoreline. The light is gold but the water is cold-looking. Dora carries her shoes in one hand.

DORA
At home my father had the whole thing arranged.
Husband by nineteen. Children. Respectability.
Proper worries on schedule.

Kafka smiles. A real smile. The kind of smile that changes his entire face.

DORA
I wanted Hebrew. Work. Palestine, maybe. At minimum a key that answered only to me.

KAFKA
In Prague even the key tends to belong to my father.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

DORA
Then stop calling it your key.

That lands more cleanly than anything sympathetic would have. They keep walking.

DORA
The camp secretary says you write. The children say you murder fish. I believe the children.

KAFKA
I'm a retired insurance inspector who writes. There's a difference.

DORA
What do you write about?

KAFKA
Impossible situations. A man wakes up an insect. Another is put on trial and never told why. Animals give lectures.

DORA
Then you've been preparing for ordinary life.

KAFKA
(surprised)
Most people flinch.

DORA
Most people prefer lies with good table manners.

Kafka looks at her and loses the careful little speech he had ready. Dora keeps walking, trusting him to catch up. He does.

CUT TO:

INT. DOCTOR'S OFFICE -- PRAGUE -- DAY

A consulting room. Not Mühlstein's --- a newer doctor, younger, with a chart that has too many entries. DR. KODYM reviews the latest X-ray without enthusiasm.

DR. KODYM
Berlin is inadvisable. The damp. The cold. The lack of consistent medical supervision.

KAFKA
I understand.

DR. KODYM
I want to be clear. A Prague sanatorium, even your sister's farm, gives you time. Berlin in winter, without proper care, takes it away.

KAFKA
How much time?

The doctor pauses. Kafka waits with the patience of a man who has spent his professional life reading evasions in claim forms.

DR. KODYM
I'm not in a position to---

KAFKA
Estimate.

Kodym closes the chart.

DR. KODYM
Stay in Prague, under care: a year, perhaps more. Berlin, as you describe it: considerably less.

KAFKA
Thank you, Doctor. That was a clear report.

He stands. Takes his hat. Kodym watches him go with the expression of a man who has just been understood perfectly and obeyed not at all.

CUT TO:

BERLIN, SEPTEMBER 1923

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

EXT. BERLIN STREET -- DAY

Kafka and Dora walk toward Steglitz carrying what they own between them. They pass the Askanischer Hof hotel. Kafka's step catches. Half a second. Dora notices. Neither speaks.

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- DAY

A small, cold apartment. Top floor. Cheap furniture. Damp walls.

Kafka and Dora are moving in together. She arranges plates in a kitchen so small that two people cannot stand in it at the same time. He carries a box of books --- his only real possessions --- and sets it down.

DORA
The stove works. I tested it this morning.

KAFKA
Does the landlord know about me?

DORA
I told her my husband was arriving.

KAFKA
(a flicker)
Your husband.

DORA
My husband-to-be, then. My--- person.

KAFKA
My person. I've been called worse.

Dora takes a small brass key from her coat pocket and drops it into his palm.

DORA
One for you. It sticks. Lift, then turn.

She puts down the plates. Turns to him. Takes his face in her hands. His face, which is thinner now, the bones more visible, the dark circles deeper.

DORA
Franz. This is ours. Cold, tiny, awful. Ours. No father in the next room. No doctor at the door. Just us.

He puts his hands over hers. His hands are cold. Hers are warm.

KAFKA
The doctor in Prague said I shouldn't come.

DORA
I know. Ottla wrote to me.

KAFKA
And you let me come anyway.

DORA
I don't let you do anything. You chose this.

KAFKA
(quietly)
I know what it costs.

DORA
Then don't waste it.

He closes his hand around the key. Says ``just us'' once, then under his breath again, testing it.

CUT TO:

INT. DISTRICT REGISTRATION OFFICE -- BERLIN -- DAY

A municipal room of benches, inkpads, impatience. Berliners wait with folders, ration slips, babies, coughs. A CLERK at a high counter works through the queue with ink on his cuff and half a cheese roll going stale beside the stamp pad.

Dora and Kafka reach the counter. Dora has the lease. Kafka keeps a handkerchief at his mouth and wills himself not to use it.

CLERK
Name.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

DORA
Diamant. And Franz Kafka. He lives with me.

CLERK
Relation?

DORA
Future husband.

CLERK
No such entry. Employment?

KAFKA
Former legal secretary to the Workers' Accident Insurance Institute in Prague.

CLERK
Current income?

KAFKA
Under paragraph twelve, co-residence may be recorded pending papers if the tenant accepts liability.

The clerk looks up for the first time. Studies him: the dark suit, the careful diction, the handkerchief he is pretending not to need.

CLERK
Thirty days. Then bring papers or I remove him.

STAMP. Across the bottom, in purple ink: `LODGER. TEMPORARY.'

EXT. DISTRICT REGISTRATION OFFICE -- CONTINUOUS

They step back into the Berlin street. Tram noise. November wind. Dora runs her thumb once over the purple word `TEMPORARY,' folds the paper back on its old crease, and hands it to Kafka.

DORA
`Lodger. Temporary.' Charming.

KAFKA
Better than omitted.

DORA
Only slightly.

She folds the paper, puts it in her coat, threads her arm through his, and walks him home.

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- EVENING

A small domestic scene. Dora cooks --- something simple. Kafka sits at the table, reading to her from a Hebrew textbook. They are studying together. His pronunciation is careful, bookish. Hers is fluid, natural.

DORA
(correcting him)
No, no. The accent is on the second syllable. You sound like a German professor.

KAFKA
I am a German professor.

DORA
You're a Czech insurance clerk who thinks he's a German professor. It's entirely different.

He laughs. Dora turns from the stove to look at him.

She brings the food to the table. Soup. Bread. A small portion. Kafka looks at it.

DORA
Eat.

KAFKA
I'm not---

DORA
Eat. The soup is for eating.

She tears the bread into smaller pieces, skims a little fat from the top of the soup with the edge of the spoon, and nudges the bowl closer to him. He eats. Slowly. Carefully. Dora keeps talking while she watches the spoon travel back and forth.

CUT TO:

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- MORNING

The apartment is tiny. Kafka writes at the table. Dora moves around him in the kitchen. He lifts an elbow; she opens a cupboard. He lowers it; she passes behind him with the kettle.

Beside his notebook: an opened letter on Institute stationery. The Kraus case resolved --- full compensation, guards in all three mills. He has folded Marschner's note back into exact thirds.

She puts her hand on his head as she passes. A gesture so casual it might be the most intimate thing anyone has ever done to him.

KAFKA
Nobody's father is in the next room. No doctor is scheduling my meals. I can hear myself think. That's new enough.

DORA
And what do you think?

KAFKA
(surprised by his own answer)
That I'm happy.

He hears himself say it. Looks down. Dora smiles and says nothing.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- EVENING

Dora comes in from errands. Kafka is at the table, writing. Not a story --- a letter. Several pages already finished. The handwriting is rapid and small.

She sets down a bag of groceries. Sees the pages. Sees the salutation: ``Dear Milena.''

DORA
How many pages?

KAFKA
Seven. She asked about the apho-
risms. It's a literary---

DORA
Seven pages.

She begins putting food away. Plates. A turnip. Bread. Her movements are harder than usual.

KAFKA
Dora, it's not---

DORA
Don't tell me what it isn't. Tell me why you can write seven pages to a woman in Vienna about what you feel, and you live with me and say `I'm happy.' Two words. I get two words and she gets an essay.

KAFKA
That isn't fair.

DORA
No. Fair is not the word for this.

She sits across from him. Direct. Not tearful --- angry in the way of a woman who has staked her life on someone and wants the full weight of him, not the version he sends by post.

DORA
You write to her about fear. About your father. About what the ill-
ness means. I sleep beside you every night and you say the soup is good and the Hebrew lesson went well.

KAFKA
I don't want to bring that into this room.

DORA
It's already in this room. It sleeps here. It coughs here. It sits at this table.

Kafka looks at the letter. At Dora. At the distance between the table and the woman three feet away.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

DORA
Which one is the letter and which one is the life? Because you have done this before, Franz. You know you have. And they left.

That lands. A long silence. The turnip and the bread sit on the counter, not put away.

KAFKA
(very quietly)
I'm afraid that if I say it out loud here, it becomes real. And then this stops being the place where I'm safe.

DORA
It is not safe. I am not safe. I am here. That is a different thing.

He reaches for her hand. She lets him take it. But she does not soften.

DORA
Finish the letter if you need to. But don't tell me you're happy and then tell Vienna the truth.

Kafka folds the letter to Milena. Places it in the drawer beside the thick, still-tied packet from Prague. Two documents addressed to people not in the room.

He looks at Dora.

KAFKA
Ask me again.

DORA
What do you think?

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

KAFKA
That I'm terrified. That the illness is ahead of me. That I hear my father's voice every time I try to eat. That I chose Berlin because I wanted one true thing before the end, and you are the true thing, and I am ruining it by being exactly who I've always been.

Dora's face does not break. Her hand tightens on his.

DORA
Better.

She gets up. Finishes putting away the groceries. He watches her. After a while, he pulls a fresh page toward him. This time he does not write to Vienna.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- NIGHT

Kafka is alone. Dora is out. The apartment is four steps from table to stove.

He rises from the table. Walks to the stove. Four steps. But the four steps take longer than they should. The room does not stretch --- the distances stay the same. It is the time that stretches. Each step lands in its own silence.

He reaches the stove. Touches it. Cold. The room is the room again. Four steps.

He walks back to the table. Sits. The apartment is tiny and ordinary and his.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- AFTERNOON

Rain at the window. Dora sorts the post. One envelope. One small brown-paper parcel with a Prague postmark. Julie Kafka's hand on the label.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

DORA
From your mother.

Kafka takes the parcel. The paper is worn at the folds, the corners rounded and dark from handling.

He opens it carefully. Inside: a thick manuscript bundle in his own handwriting. The Letter. A smaller note in Julie's hand. And loose at the bottom of the parcel, a postcard in Hermann's broad handwriting, addressed to Franz at the Berlin address and clearly dropped in by Julie as an afterthought.

INSERT --- Julie's note: ``Franz --- I could not give it to him. I kept it too long already. Forgive me. Mother.''

INSERT --- Hermann's postcard: ``The shop is busy. The new girl cannot count change. Your mother sends regards. Eat properly. Father.''

Kafka reads the note. Then the postcard. Then holds them both --- one hundred pages that never reached his father, and five lines that did.

Dora watches him.

DORA
What is it?

KAFKA
A hundred pages to my father. And a postcard from him. They have never been in the same room before.

DORA
And now?

KAFKA
Now it has come back to me. Still unopened.

He runs his thumb along the edge of the pages --- not opening them, just feeling their thickness.

DORA
Will you read it?

KAFKA
(after a beat)
No. I remember it well enough.

He places the packet in the table drawer. Closes it. The drawer does not shut cleanly. Too much paper inside.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- NIGHT

Late. The apartment is cold. The stove provides the only heat and the only light, its door open, the flames visible.

Kafka sits on the floor near the stove. Before him: a stack of manuscript pages. Handwritten. Notebooks. Loose pages. The accumulated work of years.

Dora sits behind him, legs folded, watching.

KAFKA
I want to burn these.

DORA
Are you sure?

KAFKA
They're unfinished. If I leave them, someone will mistake that for permission.

He picks up a notebook. Opens it. Reads a line. His face, in the firelight, is calm.

KAFKA
This one is about a woman who turns into a bridge. I never found the ending.

He places it in the stove. The pages curl. The fire accepts them.

He picks up another. And another. Stories, fragments, beginnings without endings. Each one goes into the fire with a strange, ceremonial tenderness.

Dora watches. She does not protest. Each notebook waits its turn on her knee before passing into his hand.

At the edge of the stack, separate from the notebooks, lies

the thick packet returned from Prague. Dora sees it.

DORA
Not that one?

KAFKA
No.

DORA
Why not?

KAFKA
Because it isn't unfinished. It's undeliverable. Different problem.

The last notebook. He holds it longer than the others.

DORA
What is that one?

KAFKA
I don't remember. That's probably the best reason to burn it.

He puts it in the fire. Watches it burn.

The apartment is warm now. He leans back against Dora. She wraps both arms around him. They sit without speaking and watch the pages cave inward to ash.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- DAY

A different day. Kafka is at the table, sorting manuscript pages into exact piles. His hand is steady, but slower than it used to be.

At one end of the table, separate from the manuscript piles, sits the thick packet returned from Prague. Still tied.

Brod has come to visit. He sits across from him, coat still on, hat still in both hands. He has traveled from Prague. Kafka is thinner than the last time they met.

BROD
You look---

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

KAFKA
Don't make me comfort you.

Brod stops. Nods once.

His eyes go to the packet at the end of the table.

BROD
And that?

KAFKA
That's different.
My mother wouldn't take it into his room.

Brod takes that in.

KAFKA
I'm not giving you that.

BROD
Because it's private?

KAFKA
Because it was addressed. That's the difference.

KAFKA
There is something practical. About the manuscripts.

Brod goes still.

KAFKA
Everything in my desk in Prague. The novels. The notebooks. The stories. Everything unpublished. Burn it.

BROD
Unread?

KAFKA
Especially unread.

BROD
Franz, if you wanted them burned, you would have burned them yourself.

KAFKA
I burned what was here. The rest are in Prague. In your reach.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

BROD
No. In your trust. That's different.

Kafka says nothing. Brod presses.

BROD
You're leaving me the crime and asking me to call it friendship.

KAFKA
I'm leaving you instructions.

BROD
For ``The Trial''? ``The Castle''?

KAFKA
Unfinished. Unpublishable.

BROD
Alive.

KAFKA
Half-built isn't shelter, Max.

BROD
Then let the rest of us stand in it.

The line lands. Kafka looks at him sharply.

BROD
You think unfinished means failure. I think it means the door is still open.

KAFKA
An open door is not the same thing as a house.

BROD
No. But men have lived by less.

BROD
You called writing prayer once. I'm not feeding those pages to a stove.

KAFKA
Prayer is not public.

BROD
No. Prayer is said to be heard.

Silence. Outside, Berlin moves through another day of its slow collapse.

KAFKA
You always liked posterity better than obedience.

BROD
And you would always rather burn it than leave it unfinished.

They hold each other's gaze. Neither persuades the other.

KAFKA
Max. As my friend. As the person I trust most in this world. Burn everything. Unread.

Brod looks at him for a long time.

BROD
I'll take care of it.

KAFKA
(softer now)
That is not the same sentence.

BROD
It's the sentence I can live with.

A beat. Then Kafka reaches across the table and takes Brod's hand. Brod covers it with his other hand. Neither lets go first.

KAFKA
Thank you, Max.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- DAY

Kafka writes a letter. Formal, careful. His best handwriting.

DORA
You're really writing to him?

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

KAFKA
One should ask properly. Even if the answer is no.

Beside the paper: the thick parcel from Prague, unopened.

DORA
The answer will be no. He's a Gerer Hasid. You're a secular Jew from Prague who writes stories about men turning into beetles.

KAFKA
I'll leave out the beetles.

She sits beside him. Reads over his shoulder.

DORA
``I am a man of modest means but sincere devotion.'' Franz, you're dying.

KAFKA
(without looking up)
Then at least the letter is honest.

He finishes the letter. Seals it. Addresses it to Dora's father in Będzin.

THREE WEEKS LATER

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- DAY

Dora holds a letter. She has already read it. Her face is composed but her hands are not.

DORA
My father consulted the Gerer Rebbe.

KAFKA
And?

DORA
The Rebbe advised against it.

A pause. Kafka nods once and squares Dora's father's letter with the edge of the table.

On the table beside Dora's letter: the thick parcel from Prague.

KAFKA
I'm sorry.

DORA
I'm not. I'm here. What does a rabbi in Poland know about us?

She sits beside him. Takes his hand. Through the window: a tram bell, a woman arguing over prices, a burst of laughter that turns into coughing. She keeps his hand in both of hers.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- NIGHT

Kafka in bed. Coughing. The cough is worse now --- deep, rattling, producing things he hides in his handkerchief before Dora can see.

Dora lies beside him. She is awake. She has been awake every night this week, listening to him breathe, counting the seconds between coughs.

DORA
(very quietly)
We need to go back. To Prague. To a doctor.

KAFKA
If I go back to Prague, I go back to my father's apartment. I go back to the room I've been trying to leave my entire life.

DORA
Franz. You need a hospital.

He doesn't answer. Another cough. This one longer, worse. When it ends, he lies very still, one hand at his ribs, waiting before he risks the next breath.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

KAFKA
(barely above a whisper)
Not yet. Not yet.

She holds him. In the dark, in the cold, in Berlin, she holds him.

FADE TO BLACK.

VI. THE LAST ROOM

KIERLING, NEAR VIENNA
APRIL 1924

EXT. SANATORIUM KIERLING -- DAY

A low building among trees. Austrian countryside. Spring. The cruel irony of flowers.

An AMBULANCE arrives. Kafka is helped out --- he can walk, but barely. Dora is with him. ROBERT KLOPSTOCK, 24, a young Hungarian medical student who has become Kafka's friend and caretaker, supports him on the other side.

Kafka looks at the building. White walls. Windows. A door.

KAFKA
(to Klopstock, hoarse)
It's smaller than the last one.

KLOPSTOCK
The rooms are good. The doctor is good.

KAFKA
You keep saying ``good.'' That worries me.

Klopstock almost smiles. Dora does not.

CUT TO:

INT. SANATORIUM KIERLING -- KAFKA'S ROOM -- DAY

A private room. A bed. A window overlooking the garden. A small table beside the bed. A water glass. A bell to call the nurse.

Kafka is settled into the bed. He is propped on pillows. His neck is swollen --- the tuberculosis has reached his larynx. Speaking is painful. Eating is worse.

DR. HOFFMANN, 50s, enters. He pauses a fraction before approaching the bed.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

DR. HOFFMANN
Herr Kafka. Welcome. We'll make you as comfortable as possible.

Kafka nods. He does not spend words.

On the bedside table: his notebook, a pencil, a glass of water.

Kafka picks up the pencil. Writes on a small slip of paper. Shows it to the doctor.

INSERT: The slip reads: ``How long do flowers usually last in a vase? I ask for planning purposes.''

The doctor reads it. Looks at Kafka. Kafka's eyes, above the swollen throat, are clear, dark, alive with a humor that refuses to stop.

CUT TO:

INT. SANATORIUM KIERLING -- KAFKA'S ROOM -- DAY

Days pass. The room becomes a world of written notes.

Kafka communicates by slips of paper. He writes them constantly --- to Dora, to Klopstock, to the nurses, to the doctor. The slips accumulate on the bedside table like fallen leaves.

A NURSE brings a tray. Soft food. Broth. A glass of fruit juice.

Kafka looks at the tray. He picks up his pencil. Writes.

INSERT: ``The fruit juice is very beautiful to look at. That is the highest compliment I am able to pay it.''

The nurse reads it. She does not know whether to smile or cry. She settles for something between the two.

Another slip, to Dora:

INSERT: ``A little water. The lilac --- could you move it closer? But not too close. Let me admire it from a politician's distance.''

Dora moves the flowers. Her hands are steady. Her face is not.

Another slip, to Klopstock:

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

INSERT: ``Do you think the lemonade is angry with me? I keep looking at it and not drinking it. That must be hurtful for a lemonade.''

Klopstock reads it. Laughs. Kafka watches him laugh and his eyes smile even though his mouth cannot.

CUT TO:

INT. SANATORIUM KIERLING -- KAFKA'S ROOM -- DAY

Kafka sits propped in bed. On his lap: galley proofs for ``A Hunger Artist.'' On the bedside tray: broth, bread, fruit juice, all barely touched.

He reads with ferocious attention, pencil in hand, correcting commas, restoring a word, refusing sloppiness even here.

Kafka reads to the final lines and stops.

From the corridor: the rattle of a lunch cart, plates, the cheerful coercion of nurses urging other patients to eat.

Kafka looks from the untouched tray to the proofs. One breath slips out through his nose. The corner of his mouth almost goes with it.

He picks up a slip of paper. Writes.

INSERT: ``The proofs are correct. Please proceed with publi-cation.''

He pauses. Pencil still on the paper. Then adds a second line.

INSERT: ``Send a copy to Hermann Kafka, Prague.''

Dora, sitting beside the bed, sees the name.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

DORA
(quietly)
Do you want him to read it?

Kafka looks at the slip. At his father's name in his own handwriting. The proofs on his lap. The untouched broth. The corridor outside where the lunch cart rattles.

He picks up the pencil. Draws one hard line through Hermann's name.

Dora says nothing. She saw the hesitation. The hesitation was longer than the line.

He folds the slip once. Unfolds it again. Leaves the crossed-out name visible, as if the act of hiding it would matter more than writing it.

His hand rests on the proof pages --- the last pages of his that will pass through his hands.

CUT TO:

INT. SANATORIUM KIERLING -- KAFKA'S ROOM -- EVENING

The light is fading. Dora sits beside the bed. She is reading to him --- from a book of fairy tales, in German. Her voice is steady and warm.

Kafka listens. His eyes are closed but he is not asleep. His hand rests on the blanket. Dora's hand covers his.

She stops reading. Looks at him.

DORA
(very softly)
Franz?

He opens his eyes.

He picks up his pencil. Writes.

INSERT: ``Keep reading. Your voice makes the room bearable.''

Dora reads. He listens. The room darkens. Outside, birds. Inside, her voice.

CUT TO:

INT. SANATORIUM KIERLING -- KAFKA'S ROOM -- DAY

Morning. Late May. The room is bright with spring light. Kafka is worse. His throat is so swollen he cannot swallow water. Melted ice stands in a glass beside the bed. Morphine has been given, but not enough.

DR. HOFFMANN stands at the foot of the bed with his case open on a chair, cuffs unfastened. KLOPSTOCK stands beside a tray with the untouched broth, spoon, and glass. DORA has edged her chair so close her knees touch the bed. She tries the spoon once at Kafka's lips. He cannot take it.

Kafka writes. Shows the slip to Hoffmann.

INSERT: ``Give me morphine, Doctor. Otherwise you are a torturer.''

DR. HOFFMANN
Herr Kafka, the dosage is already high. If I push it further, I may quiet more than the pain.

Kafka writes again, faster now. Shows it.

INSERT: ``I have been patient my entire life. Do not ask me to be patient with this.''

Hoffmann reads it. Takes off his spectacles. Cannot answer at once.

Kafka turns to Klopstock. Writes.

INSERT: ``Kill me, or else you are a murderer.''

Klopstock reads the note. Folds it once. Unfolds it. His hands shake.

KLOPSTOCK
(barely audible)
Franz...

Kafka looks at him and waits.

He reaches for the pencil again. Writes one more note, slower this time. Shows it to all three of them.

INSERT: ``No fear now.''

Dora takes his hand. He squeezes once. Klopstock turns away only far enough to steady himself.

Hoffmann prepares a larger dose with the controlled reluctance of a man who knows exactly what he is agreeing to. Kafka watches the needle go in.

The morphine reaches him. His face eases.

For a moment --- morphine-soft, impossible to verify --- the walls of the room are papered with manuscript pages. Claim forms. Notebook entries. Letters never sent. The nurse moves through the door and the pages hang like curtains around her.

Then the room is the room. The window. The garden. Spring light.

He opens his eyes once more. Looks at Dora. On her chair, half hidden beneath her shawl, the slip from the night before: ``It was the life with you. That was the real one.''

His hand moves to the pencil one last time. He writes on a slip, folds it once, and slides it under his pillow. Dora does not see what it says.

He closes his eyes.

CUT TO:

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

INT. SANATORIUM KIERLING -- KAFKA'S ROOM -- AFTERNOON

JUNE 3, 1924

The room. The bed. The window. Light.

Kafka lies still. Klopstock and Dora are present. The doctor has been called but has not arrived.

Klopstock holds Kafka's wrist. Counting. The count slows.

Dora holds Kafka's other hand. She is silent.

The room is very quiet. From outside: birdsong. The sound of wind in the garden. The sound of a world that continues.

Klopstock puts Kafka's hand down. Gently. He looks at Dora.

She knows.

Kafka's eyes are closed. Dora still holds his hand. Klopstock keeps looking at the wrist he no longer has to count.

Dora does not move. She sits holding his hand. The light in the room does not change.

FADE TO BLACK.

PRAGUE, 1924

INT. KAFKA FAMILY APARTMENT -- LIVING ROOM -- DAY

Julie waits by the table with a box from Franz's room. Brod stands before her, hat in hand. On the table beside the box: the thick sealed packet addressed ``For Father.''

JULIE
The notebooks were in the desk. This one was in mine.

Brod looks at the packet.

BROD
He sent it back to Berlin.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

JULIE
I sent it. He put it in my hands years ago. Then it came back and sat in my drawer again.

A beat.

BROD
Did Hermann ever see it?

JULIE
No. Once he reached for the household ledger and almost touched the wrong drawer. I lied before he had the handle.

BROD
Will you let me take it?

JULIE
Take it, yes. Open it, no.

BROD
Because it was for his father?

JULIE
Because it was for an afternoon that never happened.

BROD
He trusted you with that choice.

JULIE
No. He put it in my hands and waited for me to choose which of them I could bear at supper.

Brod has no answer for that.

JULIE
The rest he left among friends. This one he left with me.

She pushes the box toward him. Leaves the packet where it is a beat longer, then places it on top.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

JULIE
Do with the others what your conscience can survive. This one stays tied. If Franz had wanted it opened, he knew your address.

Brod nods. Takes the box and the packet.

INT. MAX BROD'S APARTMENT -- NIGHT

Brod sits at his desk. Before him: stacks of manuscripts. Notebooks. Loose pages. The contents of Kafka's desk, delivered from Prague. Mixed among them: a Hebrew exercise page in Dora's hand and the folded Berlin registration paper, its purple stamp still visible at the edge. Separate from them: the thick sealed packet in Kafka's hand, addressed ``For Father.'' Beneath it, in smaller script: ``Via Mother.''

He touches the packet once. Reads the front again. He does not untie it.

He opens a notebook. Reads the first page. Then another page. Then another. His hand trembles slightly.

Among the notebooks, loose in the box: a single slip of paper, folded once. Smaller than the others. Dora has placed it on top with a note: ``Found under his pillow.''

Brod unfolds it. Reads it. His face goes still.

He refolds the slip and puts it in his breast pocket. He does not place it with the manuscripts. He does not place it with the letter.

At the edge of the desk: a matchbox. He picks it up. Weighs it in his hand.

He sets it beside a manuscript whose cover page reads, in Kafka's handwriting: ``DER PROZESS'' --- The Trial.

He opens the manuscript. Reads the first line. Stops. Reads it again.

Then he takes the matchbox, puts it in the desk drawer, and closes the drawer.

He pulls the next manuscript toward him.

The camera pulls back. Brod at his desk, surrounded by his dead friend's work. The lamp burning. The city outside.

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT -- BERLIN-STEGLITZ -- NIGHT

The room is empty now. The small table. Two chairs. The stove, cold.

Moonlight through the window falls on a Hebrew primer, one chipped bowl, the folded Berlin registration paper with the purple stamp still showing, and a small brass key.

The table drawer is shut. For the first time it closes all the way.

Through the window: Berlin. Bare trees. Tram wires. The narrow street below.

The table. The chairs. The light.

Hold.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END

Development example. All casting, financing and awards language is illustrative; no attachments confirmed.